MUSIC

TALENT ON TRACK

Singing sensation **Anuv Jain**'s songs are mostly based on personal experience. His latest single, 'Antariksh', is all about unexpressed love



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With over 5 million monthly listeners on Spotify alone and a headlining slot at the last edition of the Bacardi NH7 Weekender festival, Anuv Jain is the most successful singer-songwriter to emerge out of India's independent music scene this decade. But unlike many of his counterparts who claim they don't care too much about stream counts, Jain readily admits that he pays attention to the plays.

"I come from a business family," says the 28-year-old, Ludhiana-based musician. "I'm a numbers guy and keep rack. At the same time, I don't make that my entire world. If a song doesn't do that well [initially], I've realised it can pick up after two years."

Jain knows this from experience. His debut single 'Baarishein', which he uploaded on YouTube in 2012 when he was 17 and released officially in 2016, became a hit only in 2020 after it went viral on short-format video platforms. Since then, he's steadily built a large and loyal following with Gen-Z listeners who relate to his earnestly delivered confessional lyrics that document love lost, love past, love unrequited and, as on his new single 'Antariksh', love unexpressed.

They're all based on personal experiences or, in some cases, observations of experiences had by the people closest to him. 'Riha' and 'Maula', for example, are both dedications to his late father, but written from his mother's and sister's points of view, respectively. 'Gul' was penned to help a friend get over a break-up. 'Alag Aasman', on the other hand, is about a long-distance relationship. The stories behind the songs are familiar to fans who flock to his concerts where he intersperses the tunes with anecdotes.

Though he's able to hold the attention of thousands while standing alone on stage with just his guitar for accompaniment, Jain—who first gained an audience by singing live on Instagram at 3 a.m. with the lights turned off—says it's only now that he's comfortable with the spotlight. The music video for 'Antariksh' is just the second of his promotional clips in which he appears. "To put my face out there and become more confident in front of the camera" is one of his goals for 2023. On December 31 or January 1 every year, Jain prepares a list of career objectives, which typically includes a certain number of tracks to release and cities to tour.

Despite his ambitions, Jain has remained firm about not signing with a label. "I'm not a very fast writer, I like to take my time," he says. "When you do that, you want to be your own boss. You don't want any external pressure." Equally importantly, staying independent means he retains all the rights to his music. "I feel a sense of pride that I own 100 per cent. The thing with me is I'm not looking for a peak, I'm looking for stability. I want people to be listening to my songs ten to 20 years down the line." ■

Amit Gurbaxani